

strident, and ongoing, criticism was that his argumentation was theological, because he believed in, and defended, the divine inspiration of the NT. It is here that epistemology comes in: the attacks against Burgon were really a malignant epistemology attacking a godly epistemology.

It is impossible to work without presuppositions, in any discipline. It is therefore perverse to criticize someone for having them. That said, presuppositions can, and should be evaluated. Once evaluated, a presupposition may reasonably be criticized. The concrete (empirical) evidence is presumably the same for everyone, but the interpretation that one gives to the evidence will be controlled (or at least heavily influenced) by his presuppositions. It follows that every honest scholar should openly state his presuppositions. To fail to do so is reprehensible.¹ For someone who does not state his presuppositions to criticize someone else for doing so is worse than perverse—to pretend that he himself does not have any is depraved (well, maybe just brainwashed and blinded).

Although I am not in Burgon's class as a scholar (living in the Amazon jungle with an indigenous people did not permit scholarly research), I also have been constantly criticized for openly stating my belief that God both inspired and preserved the NT. It is even alleged that such a belief makes it impossible to do objective scholarly work. Well, well, well, if a servant of God cannot do objective scholarly work, then a servant of Satan most certainly cannot do so either. So on what basis does a servant of Satan criticize a servant of God? He does so on the basis of his presuppositions, his epistemology.

A brother who lives in Curitiba, the state capital of Paraná, recently wrote an introduction to a book in Portuguese that I am co-authoring. He praises my work from the point of view of epistemology. I found his argument to be so interesting (it inspired this article) that I translated it, sent the translation to him to be sure I got it right, and asked his permission to use it. His name is Carlos Eduardo Rangel Xavier. I ask you to concentrate on his argument, and not be distracted by the praise.

Dr. Pickering's work within NT textual criticism (although he himself does not consider himself a textual critic²), especially in the collating of manuscripts, is impressive and incomparable.

what has been written was done by 'parrots'.

¹ While I was a student in theological seminary we were taught that we should never question someone else's motives. Now really, where do you suppose that 'doctrine' came from?

² True. I consider myself a textual student; the Text is above me. A critic is above the text. I do not have a theory of textual criticism; my theory is about textual preservation.